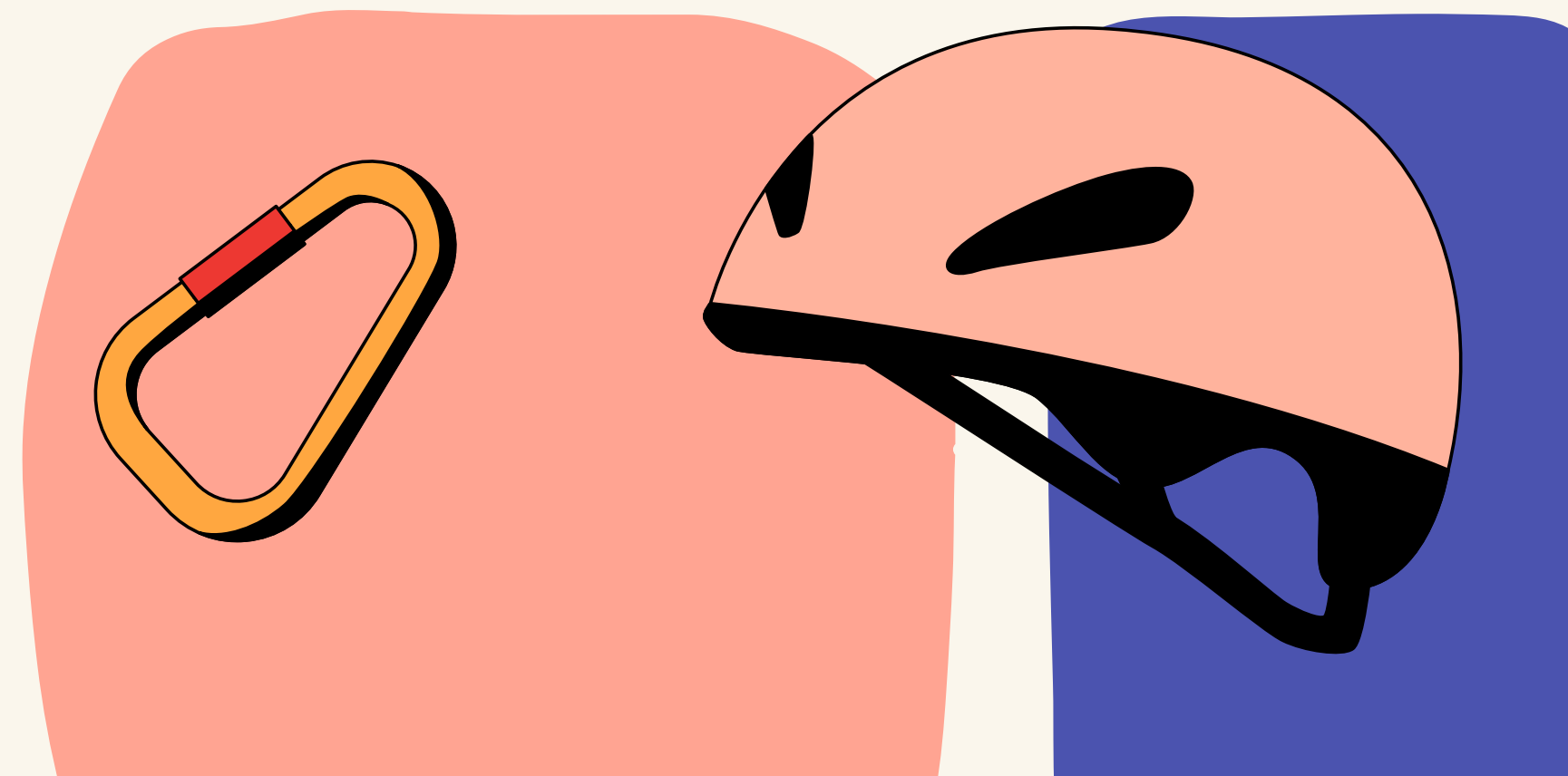


GR1

THE CLIMB SPACE

Needfinding Report



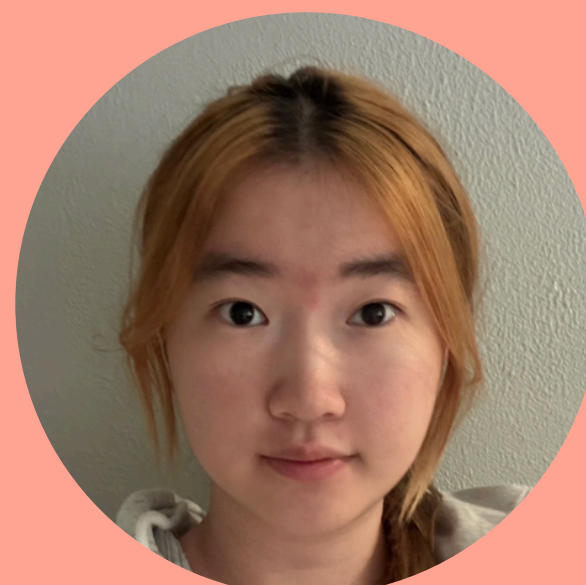
MEET THE TEAM



Hyun Cho

MAT

Korea, Seoul



Shuang Li

CS

China



Xandra Wong

CS

Malaysia, KL

DOMAIN SELECTION

HOW DID WE ARRIVE AT
BOULDERING?

WHAT INTERESTING
CHALLENGES DO
PEOPLE FACE?

CAN AI BE USED
TO IMPROVE IT?

COULD
ACCESSIBILITY
BE IMPROVED
HERE?

WHAT ACTIVITY INVOLVES
LEARNING,
DECISION-MAKING,
AND SOCIAL INTERACTION?

- Recruitment channels: gym community / friends of friends / local climbing circle
- Criteria: non-UCSB students; climbs regularly; variety in experience level; mix of body types
- Compensation: \$10 Starbucks gift card

FINDING PARTICIPANTS

WHO DID WE MEET?



DAN

30-YEAR-OLD
SCIENTIST



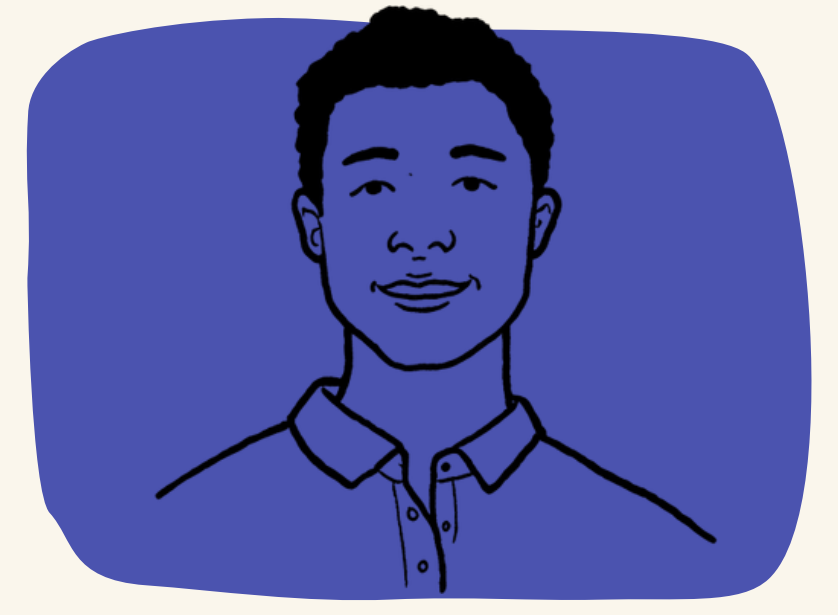
JUNE

18-YEAR-OLD
COLLEGE STUDENT



JULIE

25-YEAR-OLD
ELECTRICAL ENGINEER



MIKE

PROGRAMMER

*names are pseudonyms

GUIDING QUESTIONS

HOW OFTEN DO YOU CLIMB IN A TYPICAL WEEK?

HOW DID YOU GET INTO BOULDERING/CLIMBING?

WHAT TOOLS (IF ANY) DO YOU USE DURING SESSIONS?

WHAT DO YOU STRUGGLE WITH THE MOST AT EACH LEVEL?

DO YOU THINK CLIMBING IS A SOCIAL SPORT?

ARE THERE ASPECTS THAT ARE MORE HELPFUL WHEN YOU CLIMB WITH OTHERS?

WHY DO YOU ENJOY CLIMBING?

HOW LONG HAVE YOU BEEN CLIMBING?

WHEN APPROACHING A NEW ROUTE WHAT IS YOUR USUAL PROCESS?

DO YOU TRACK ANYTHING DURING OR AFTER A SESSION?

DO YOU USUALLY GO WITH OTHERS OR ALONE?

WHAT IS THE MOST MEMORABLE EXPERIENCE RELATED TO CLIMBING?

WHERE DO YOU USUALLY CLIMB?

WHAT LEVEL ARE YOU AT?

DO PHYSICAL ATTRIBUTES HAVE A STRONG INFLUENCE WHEN CLIMBING?

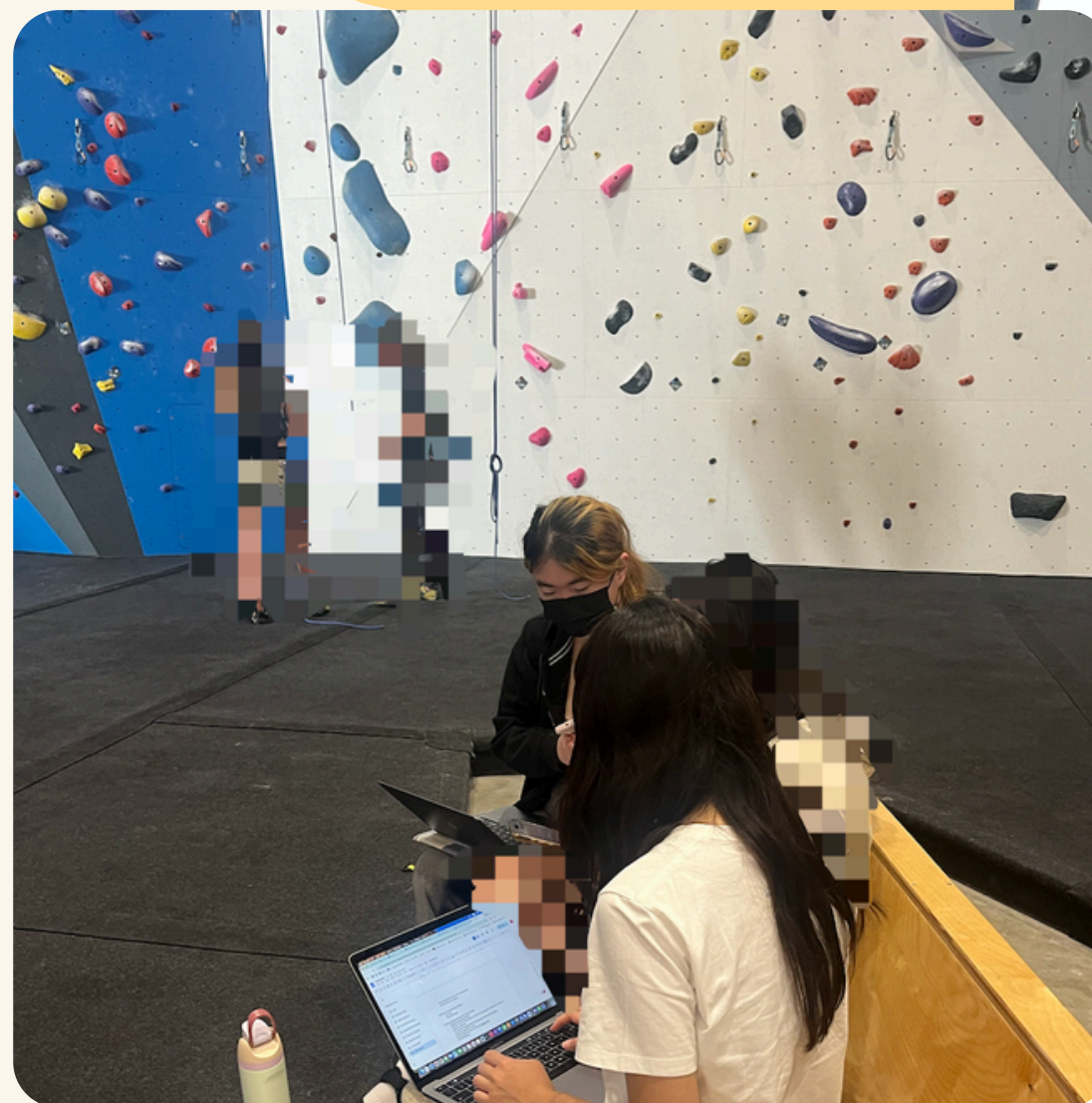
ARE THERE MOMENTS WHERE YOU FEEL STUCK, CONFUSED, OR DISCOURAGED?

HAVE YOU MADE ANY NEW FRIENDS THROUGH CLIMBING?

HAVE YOU EVER FOUND INSPIRATION BY WATCHING OTHER CLIMBERS?

GR1

INTERVIEW RESULTS



**DAN**

LOCATION: IV SAN CLEMENTE
USER TYPE: AVERAGE USER
INTERVIEWER: HYUN
RECORDER: XANDRA
SCRIBE: SHUANG

Dan is a beginner-to-intermediate climber with one and a half years of experience. He started bouldering as a way to relax and spend time with friends. For him, bouldering is a mentally engaging and social activity rather than a purely physical one.

“So I think it’s good to have people around. They can help you by telling you what to do from the ground.”

“I don’t think I ever went (climbing) alone”

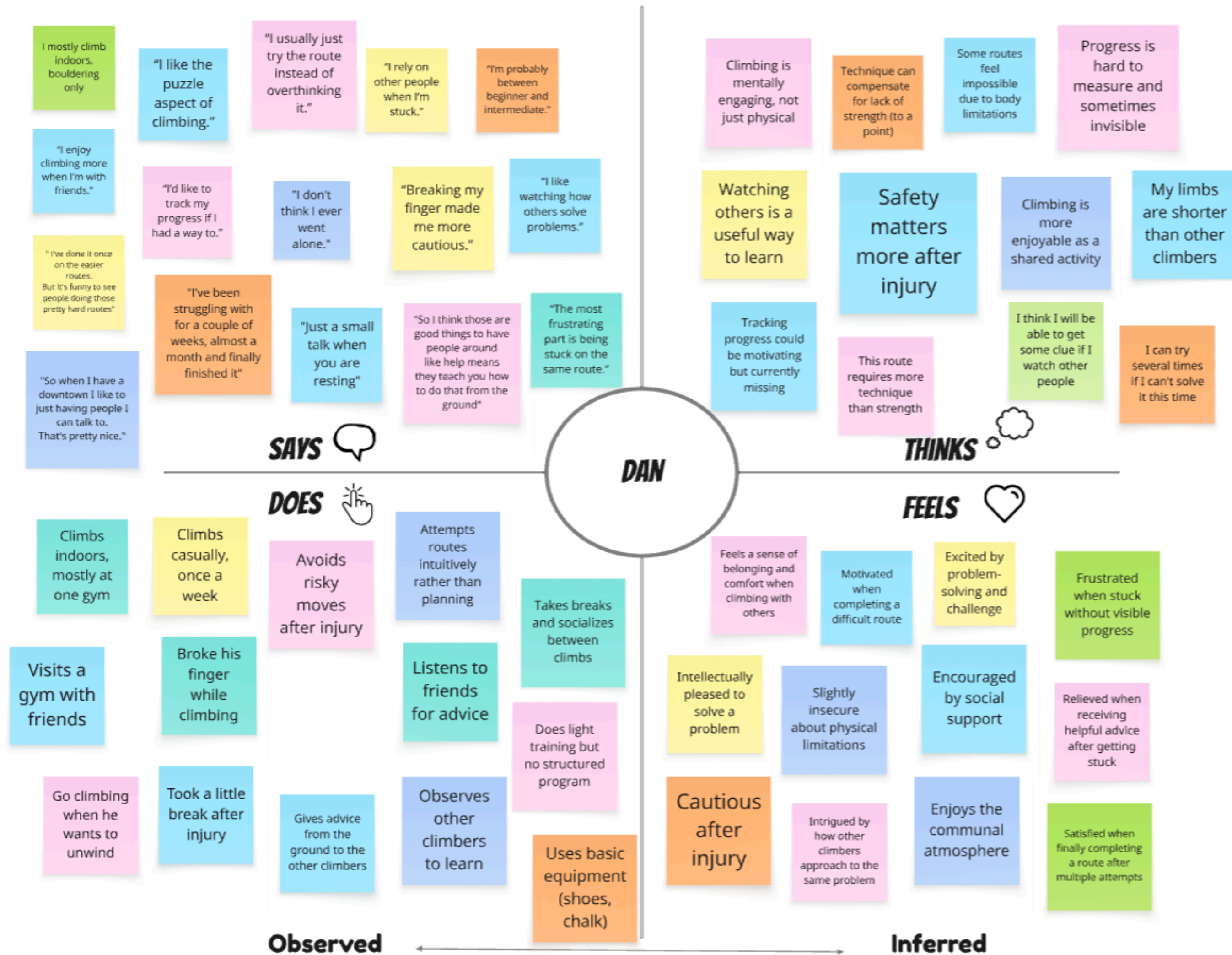
GR1

EMPATHY MAP



DAN

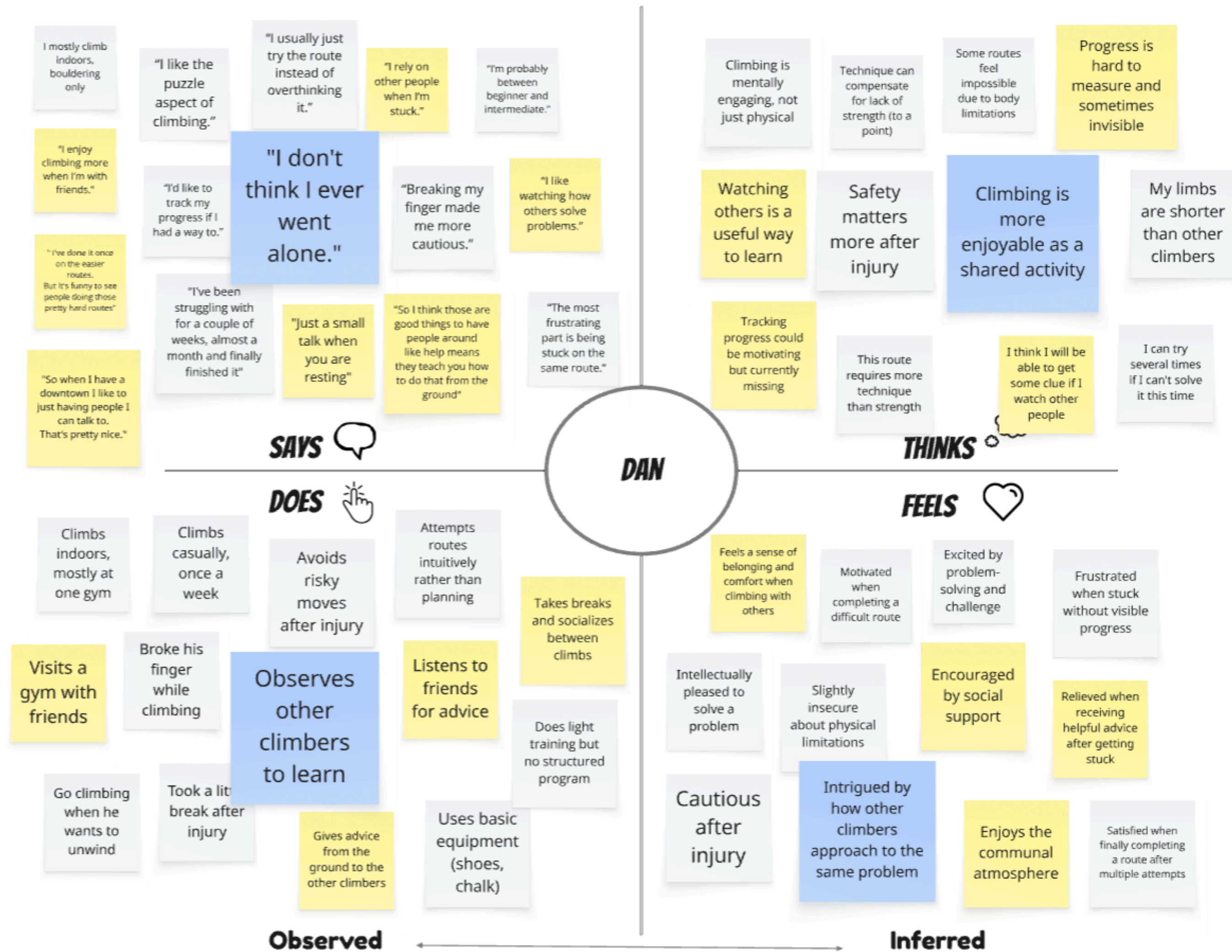
LOCATION: IV SAN CLEMENTE
USER TYPE: AVERAGE USER
INTERVIEWER: HYUN
RECORDER: XANDRA
SCRIBE: SHUANG



GR1

EMPATHY MAP

- Social learning
- Progress visibility





*"I don't think I ever went
(climbing) alone"*

INSIGHT

- Motivated by community + puzzle-solving
- Learns by trying first + watching others / friends' coaching
- Frustrated by binary feedback ("succeed or fail")

NEED

- Visible incremental progress on a route
- Simple technique guidance (balance/footwork/efficiency)
- Easy access to social feedback in the moment

**JUNE**

LOCATION: THE PAD CLIMBING GYM
USER TYPE: EXTREME USER
INTERVIEWER: XANDRA
RECORDER: SHUANG
SCRIBE: HYUN

June is an advanced climber with 4 years of experience and considers herself the average casual-serious, recreational climber.

“Betas are mainly set by males who are at least 5’7”

“If I could see the progress of everything I've done so far, I would be very interested in that”

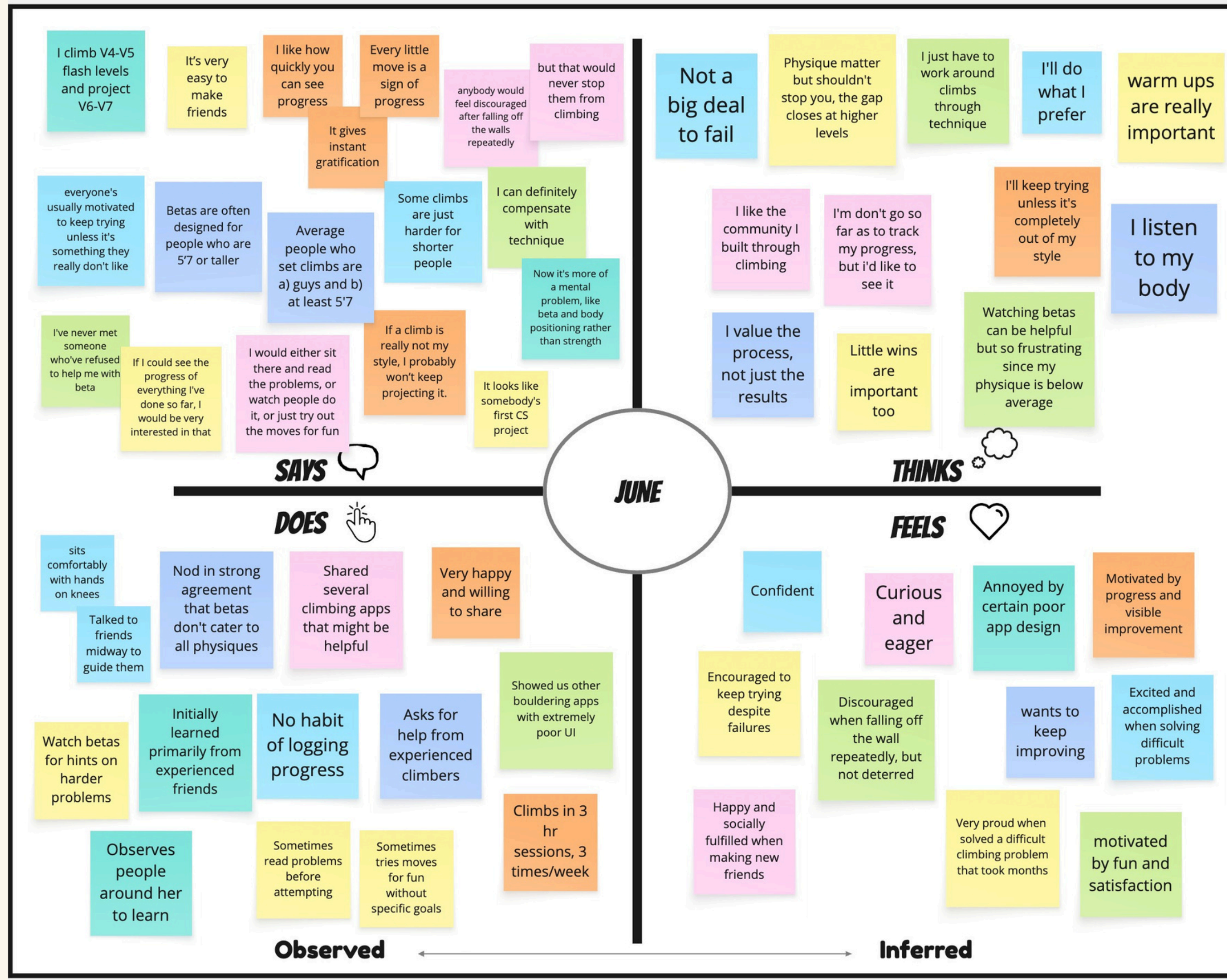
GR1

EMPATHY MAP



JUNE

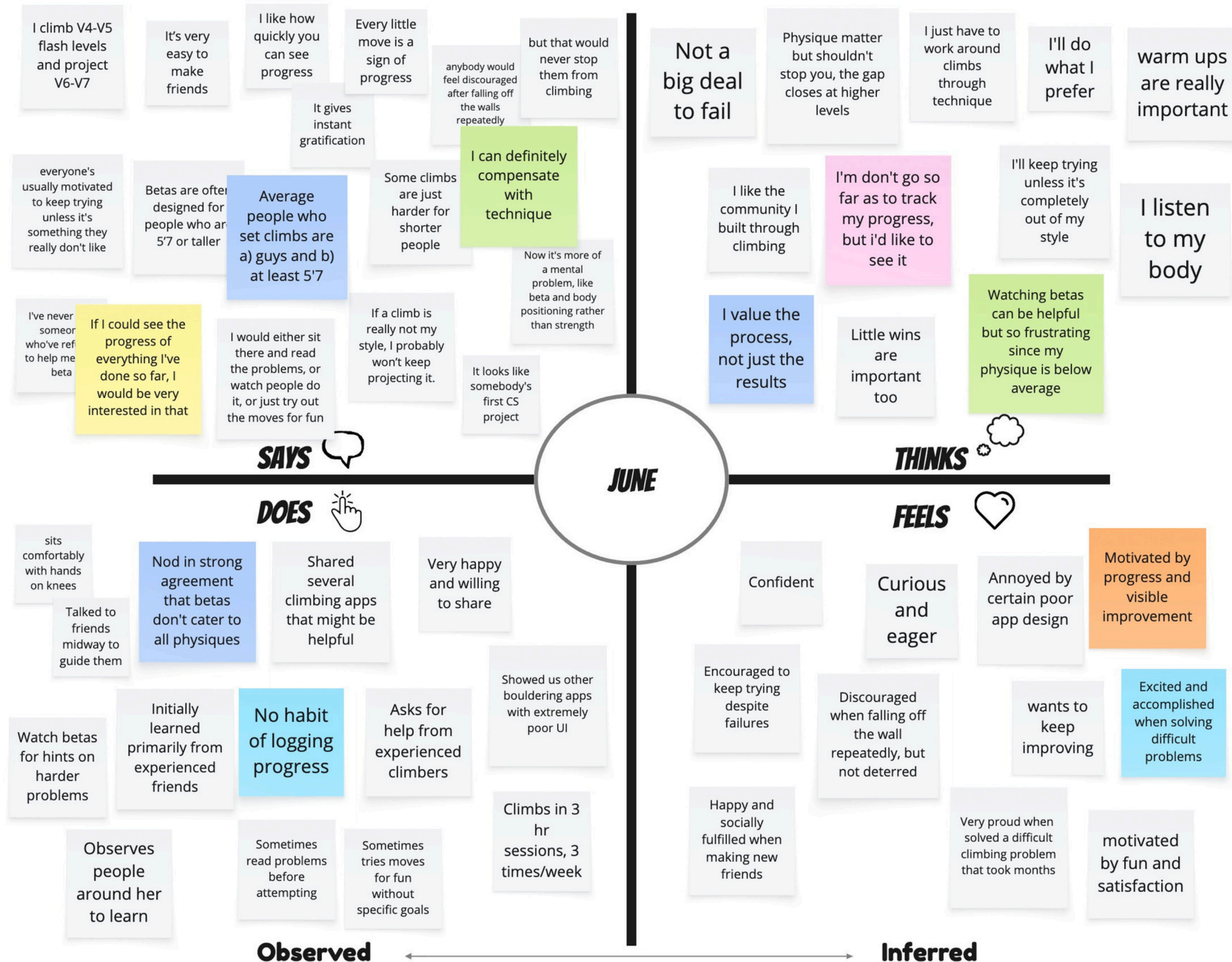
LOCATION: THE PAD CLIMBING GYM
USER TYPE: EXTREME USER
INTERVIEWER: XANDRA
RECORDER: SHUANG
SCRIBE: HYUN



GR1

EMPATHY MAP

- Beta mismatch
- Progress visibility





*"Betas are mainly set by males
who are at least 5'7"*

INSIGHT

- Strongly motivated by visible progress but doesn't like logging it
- Betas can be unhelpful due to different physiques
- At higher levels, technique can compensate physique

NEED

- Body-appropriate beta that accounts for height, strength and reach differences
- Ways to compare multiple betas for the same problem
- Ways to visualize her progress for motivation

**JULIE**

LOCATION: THE PAD CLIMBING GYM
USER TYPE: AVERAGE USER
INTERVIEWER: HYUN
RECORDER: SHUANG
SCRIBE: XANDRA

Julie is a beginner climber who just started climbing 6 months ago.

“Watching people doesn't really help cause they can do crazy stuff”

“I don't like people telling you what to do though”

GR1

EMPATHY MAP



JULIE

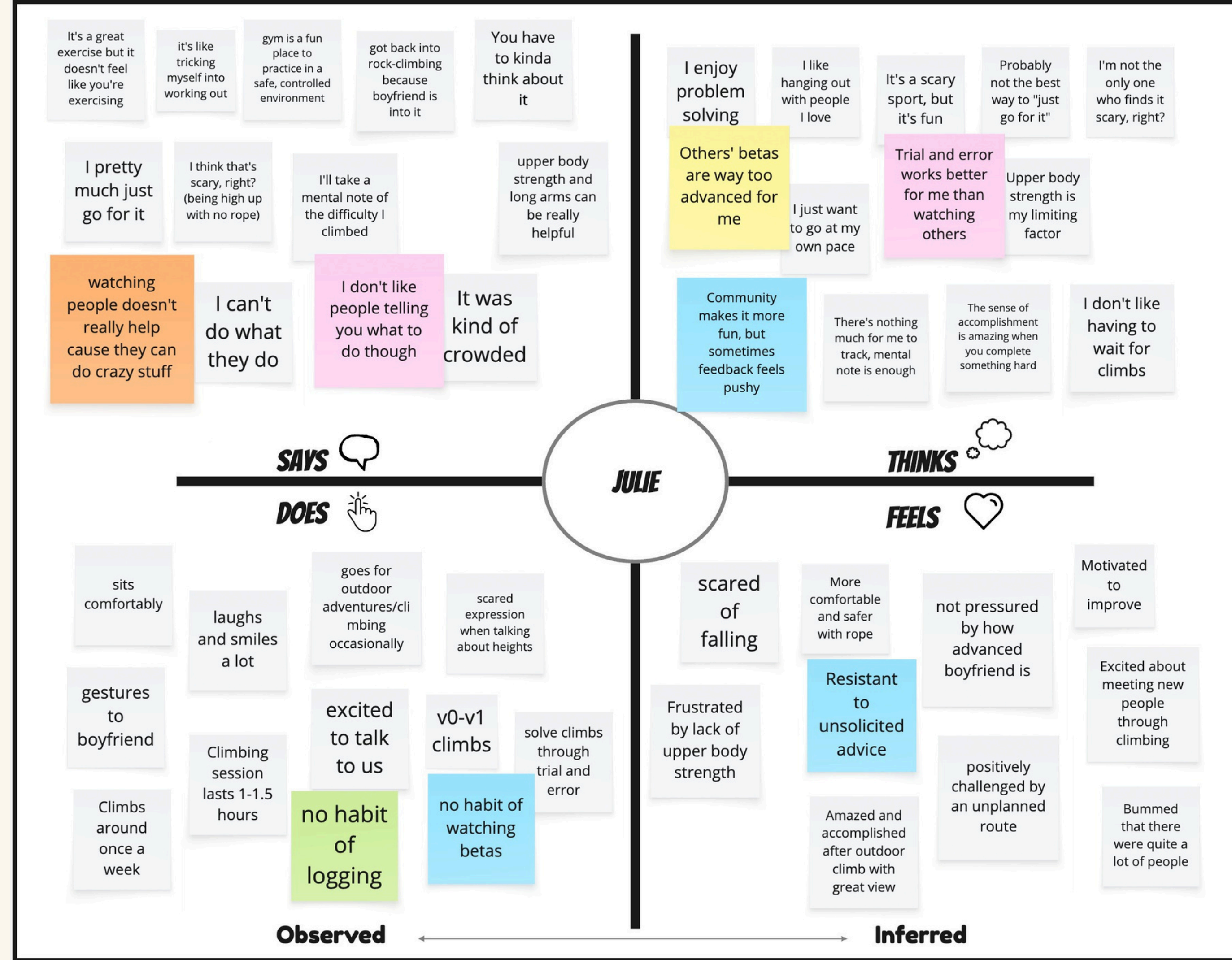
LOCATION: THE PAD CLIMBING GYM
USER TYPE: AVERAGE USER
INTERVIEWER: HYUN
RECORDER: SHUANG
SCRIBE: XANDRA



GR1

EMPATHY MAP

- Beta mismatch
- Autonomy





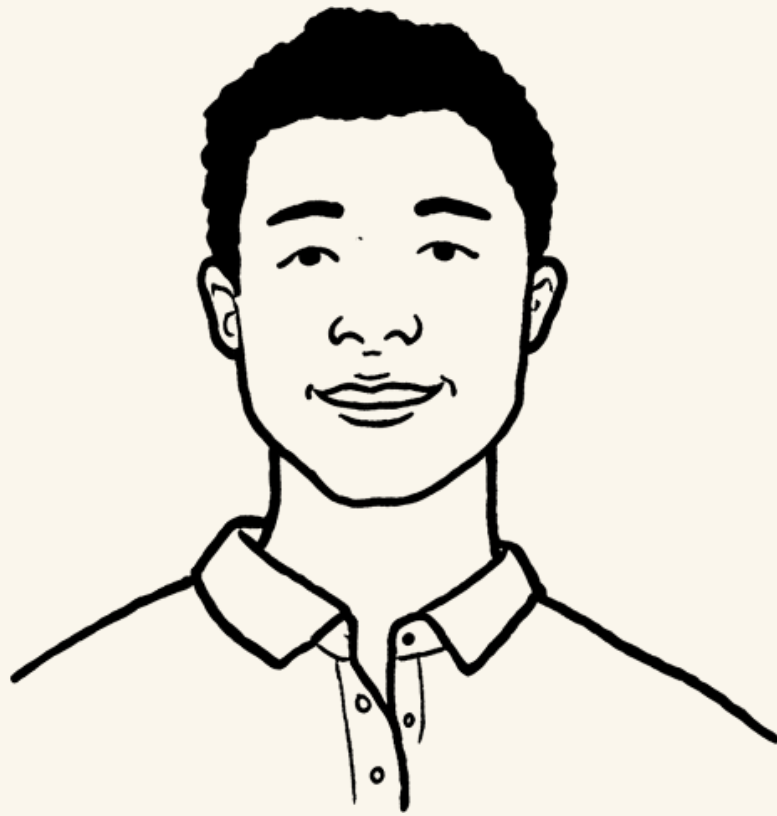
"Watching people doesn't really help cause they can do crazy stuff"

INSIGHT

- Relies on trial-and-error and finds watching experts less helpful
- Feels limited by fear of height and lack of upper body strength
- Values social support but dislikes being explicitly told what to do

NEED

- Beginner-friendly guidance that supports exploration
- Guidance to overcome physique limitation (technique etc)
- Supportive feedback that preserves her autonomy

**MIKE**

LOCATION: VIA ZOOM
USER TYPE: EXTREME USER
INTERVIEWER: SHUANG
RECORDER: XANDRA
SCRIBE: HYUN

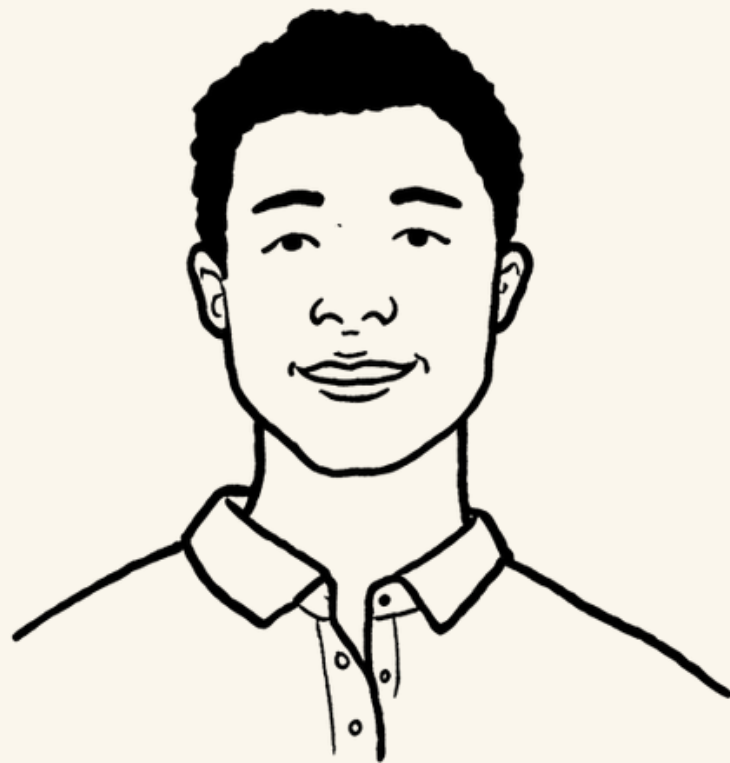
Mike is an engineer who started bouldering in June 2024. He climbs 2 to 3 times a week and is generally considered an advanced climber.

“Climbing is like programming”

“Different people have different beta”

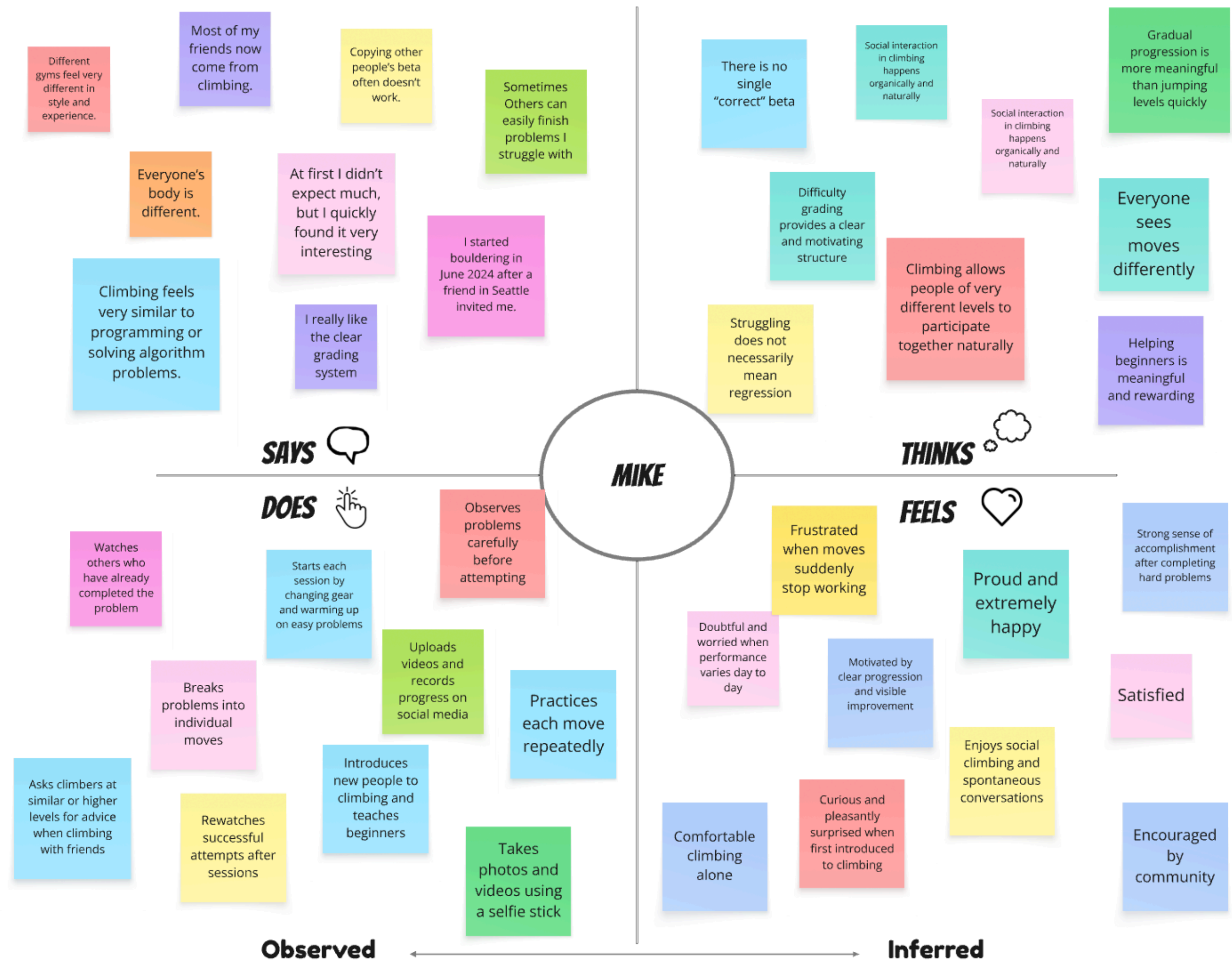
GR1

EMPATHY MAP



MIKE

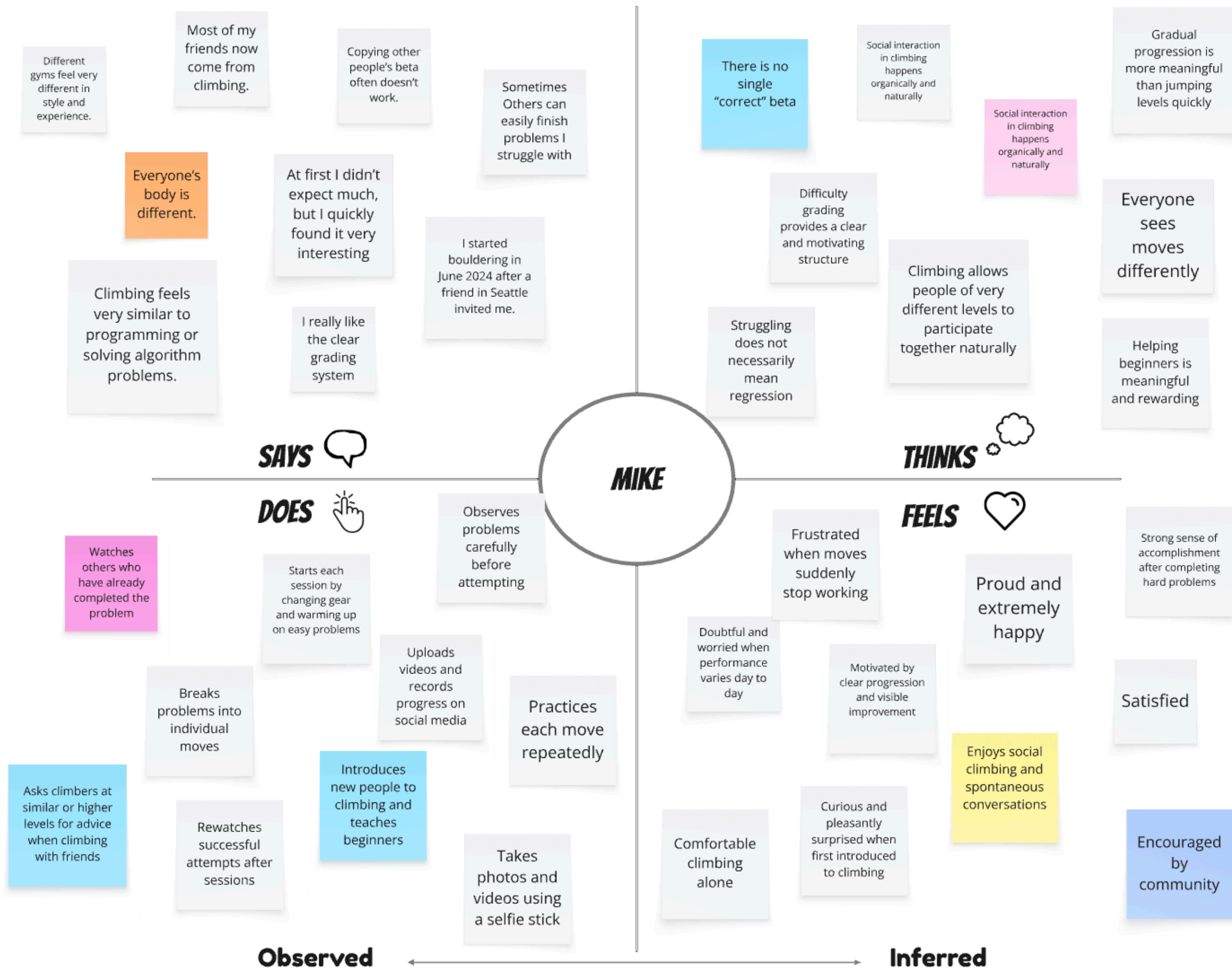
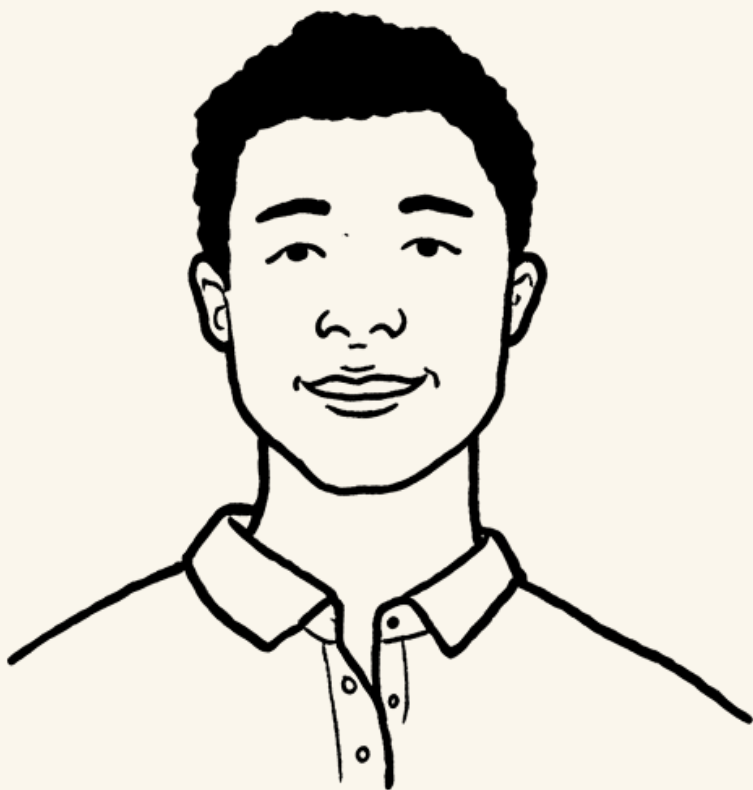
LOCATION: VIA ZOOM
USER TYPE: EXTREME USER
INTERVIEWER: SHUANG
RECORDER: XANDRA
SCRIBE: HYUN

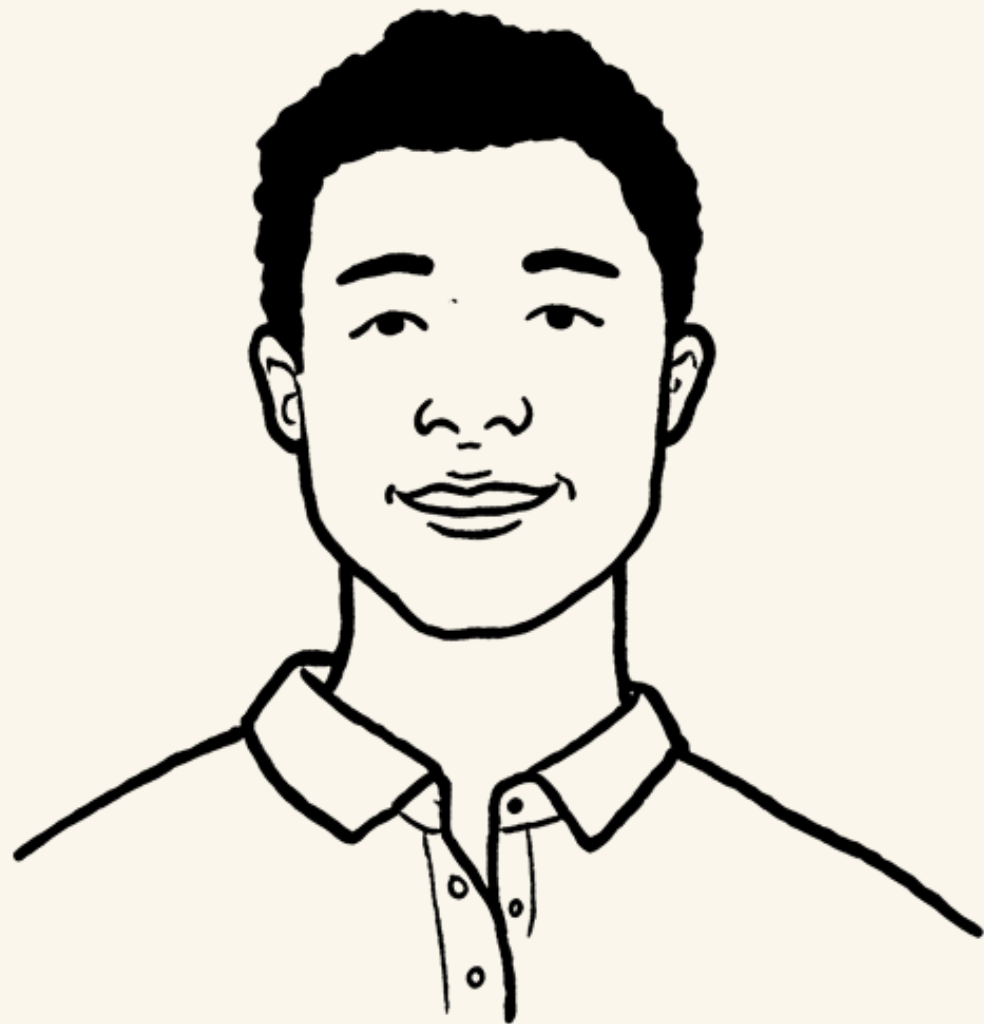


GR1

EMPATHY MAP

- Beta mismatch
- Finding friends





"Climbing is like programming"

INSIGHT

- Treats bouldering as a cognitive problem-solving process
- When "standard" beta does not fit his body, he feels frustrated and doubts his progress
- Learns best by seeing multiple betas and observing nearby climbers

NEED

- Body-appropriate beta rather than a single "standard" solution
- Easy ways to compare different strategies on the same problem
- Social support to stay motivated across multiple sessions
- Simple ways to connect with climbers working on the same problems

KEY LEARNINGS



Most climbers think the shared betas (example solutions) are designed for a standard body that doesn't match theirs



Most climbers enjoy solving problems with others, not solitarily, though some feel pressured or discouraged by their advice



When climbers get stuck, they often think it's personal failure rather than learning process



Climbers want to visualize their progress

NARROW PROBLEM AREA SCOPE

DECIDE ON WHICH ASPECT
OF BOULDERING WE WANT
TO TARGET

INTERVIEW MORE USERS

GATHER MORE INFORMATION
TO DEVELOP MORE INSIGHTS

NEXT STEPS

DEVELOP POVS, HMW STATEMENTS AND EXPERIENCE PROTOTYPES

BRAINSTORM SOLUTIONS AND TEST
OUR ASSUMPTIONS

GR1

THANKYOU



CLIMBSPACE

APPENDIX



APPARATUS USED FOR INTERVIEW:
PHONE RECORDING, GOOGLE DOC FOR
NOTE TAKING
ZOOM MEETING/ZOOM RECORDING
CLOVA NOTE(TRANSCRIBING AI)

DAN WAS RECRUITED AT THE UCSB RECREATION CENTER. HE WAS APPROACHED WHILE SPENDING TIME AT THE FACILITY, AND ALTHOUGH HE IS NOT A UCSB STUDENT, HE AGREED TO PARTICIPATE IN THE INTERVIEW. HE WAS SELECTED BECAUSE HE FIT THE TARGET USER GROUP AND WAS AVAILABLE AT THE TIME.

JUNE WAS RECRUITED IN THE PARKING LOT OF THE PAD CLIMBING GYM IN SANTA BARBARA. SHE WAS IDENTIFIED AS AN EXTREME USER BECAUSE SHE CAME TO THE GYM SPECIFICALLY FOR CLIMBING AND HAD EXTENSIVE EXPERIENCE. SHE WAS ACCOMPANIED BY TWO NON-USERS, WHICH MADE HER PERSPECTIVE ESPECIALLY VALUABLE FOR COMPARISON.

APPENDIX



APPARATUS USED FOR INTERVIEW:
PHONE RECORDING, GOOGLE DOC FOR
NOTE TAKING
ZOOM MEETING/ZOOM RECORDING
CLOVA NOTE(TRANSCRIBING AI)

JULIE WAS RECRUITED AT THE PAD CLIMBING GYM AS SHE WAS LEAVING AFTER A CLIMBING SESSION. SHE WAS A BEGINNER CLIMBER WHO CAME WITH HER EXPERIENCED BOYFRIEND. SHE WAS SELECTED TO REPRESENT NOVICE USERS WHO ARE INTRODUCED TO CLIMBING THROUGH MORE EXPERIENCED PARTNERS.

MIKE WAS RECRUITED THROUGH A PERSONAL CONNECTION, AS HE IS A FRIEND OF THE INTERVIEWER'S OLDER BROTHER. HE WAS SELECTED TO PARTICIPATE DUE TO HIS EXTENSIVE EXPERIENCE AND DIFFERING GENDER AND BODY TYPE.